Rebecca: Key Quotations

Exam code: 0475 & 0992

Download PDF

Written by: Nick Redgrove
Reviewed by: Kate Lee
Updated on 15 October 2024

Key Quotations

Remember the assessment objectives explicitly state that you should be able to "use textual references, **including** quotations". This means summarising, paraphrasing, referencing single words and referencing plot events are all as valid as using quotations in demonstrating that you understand the text. It is important that you remember that you can evidence your knowledge of the text in these two equally valid ways: both through references **to** it and direct quotations **from** it.

Overall, you should aim to secure a strong knowledge of the text, rather than memorising quotations, as this will enable you to respond to the question. It is the quality of your knowledge of the text that will enable you to select references effectively.

If you are going to revise quotations, the best way is to group them by character, or theme. Below you will find definitions and analysis of the best quotations, arranged by the following themes:

- Identity
- Power and control
- Deception and secrets
- Class divisions

Identity

Through this theme, du Maurier explores self-perception, societal expectations and the influence of the past on one's sense of identity. Societal expectations, particularly those within the aristocratic ideals depicted in the novel, mean that characters are subjected to rigid norms that present a challenge to their identity and autonomy.

"I realise, every day, that things I lack, confidence, grace, beauty, intelligence, wit – Oh, all the qualities that mean most in a woman – she possessed" – Narrator, Chapter 11

Meaning and context

- In this quote, the narrator goes back to Manderley and finds Frank there

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

Analysis

- This quote reflects the narrator's deep sense of inadequacy and insecurity as she compares herself to Rebecca
- The narrator's acknowledgement of lacking qualities such as confidence, grace, beauty, intelligence and wit reveals her feelings of inferiority:
  - The narrator perceives Rebecca as the embodiment of feminine perfection
  - This idealisation becomes a significant narrative element and influences the narrator's behaviour
- The qualities listed are also traditionally associated with societal expectations for women, particularly those within the aristocracy during this era:
  - The narrator's struggle reflects the pressure to conform to these expectations as she assumes the role of the lady of Manderley
- The societal norms dictate her sense of self-worth and contribute to the challenges she faces in asserting her identity:
  - The societal memory of Rebecca influences not only how others view the narrator but also how she views herself

Help me understand

"She's the real Mrs de Winter, not you. Why don't you leave Manderley to her?" – Mrs Danvers, Chapter 18

Meaning and context

- This quote occurs the morning after the Manderley ball when the narrator goes to confront Mrs Danvers

Analysis

- Mrs Danvers's declaration illustrates the symbolic weight of Rebecca's spirit and memory at Manderley:
  - Even in death, Rebecca continues to exert a powerful influence over the estate
  - This symbolism contributes to the Gothic and mysterious tone of the novel
- In this quote, Mrs Danvers demonstrates her deep devotion to Rebecca and this loyalty transcends the boundaries of death
- By insisting that Rebecca is the true mistress of Manderley, she conveys her refusal to accept the second Mrs de Winter in this role

Power and control

Rebecca explores how characters maintain power over others through manipulation, intimidation and other psychological tools. The narrator's weakness exposes her to those who are more powerful than her and characters like Mrs Danvers use her weakness to frighten, intimidate and manipulate her.

Narrator, Chapter 21

Meaning and context

- This quote occurs when the full truth about Rebecca's death and the events leading up to it have been fully revealed
- In this chapter, the narrator reflects on the aftermath of this revelation

Analysis

- This quote demonstrates the change in perspective of the narrator:
  - The phrase "she could not hurt me" indicates a change in the power dynamics between the narrator and Rebecca
  - The narrator, initially threatened by Rebecca, realises she no longer wields any power over her
- The imagery of Rebecca's power dissolving "into the air, like mist" suggests an irreversible fading of power
- The phrase "she would never haunt me again" underscores the narrator's liberation from Rebecca's grip and her feelings of empowerment:
  - This quote conveys the narrator's transformation as a character

"I can't forget what it has done to you… It's gone forever, that funny, young, lost look that I loved. It won't come back again. I killed that too when I told you about Rebecca…You are so much older…" – Maxim, Chapter 21

Meaning and context

- In this chapter, Maxim reveals the truth about the circumstances of Rebecca's death
- He expresses his regret about telling the narrator the truth

Analysis

- In this quote, Maxim conveys a deep sense of regret and sorrow
- The phrase "it's gone forever, that funny, young, lost look that I loved" suggests that the narrator's innocence and youthfulness has been **irrevocably** altered:
  - The revelation has robbed the narrator of her naivety, which Maxim had found endearing
- Further, the phrase "you are so much older now" implies a loss of innocence:
  - While Maxim laments the loss of his wife's innocence, he also recognises the growth that accompanies it
  - This aligns to the Gothic as the corruption and loss of one's innocence is a common element of this genre

"She's still mistress here, even if she is dead" – Mrs Danvers, Chapter 18

Meaning and context

- In this chapter, the narrator is exploring the west wing (Rebecca's domain) and encounters Mrs Danvers

Analysis

influence of Rebecca's memory

- Despite her death, Mrs Danvers considers her to be the true mistress of Manderley
- It serves to contrast Rebecca with the second Mrs de Winter
- It illustrates the power and dominance that Mrs Danvers has over the narrator
- It also links to how the past continues to shape the present

"The letter R was the last to go, it twisted in the flame, it curled outwards for a moment, becoming larger than ever. Then it crumpled too; the flame destroyed it" – Narrator, Chapter 6

Meaning and context

- In this chapter, the narrator looks at the poetry book Maxim had given to her, while Maxim speaks with Mrs Van Hopper
- The narrator tears out the inscription from Rebecca and throws it into the fire

Analysis

- The motif of fire recurs twice in the novel: in this chapter and again when Manderely is ablaze at the end of the novel:
  - Fire symbolises a purification and this action foreshadows the end of the novel when Manderley is on fire
- The letter R is the last to burn and alludes to the enduring memory of Rebecca:
  - Despite the narrator tearing apart the inscribed page from the book, the spirit of Rebecca persists

Deception and secrets

The tension between appearance and reality contributes to the mysterious tone of the novel. The text explores the consequences of hidden truths and the impact of deception and secrets on characters and their relationships.

"I never go near the bloody place, or that God-damned cottage. And if you had my memories you would not want to go there either, or talk about it, or even think about it" Maxim, Chapter 10

Meaning and context

- This quote occurs after the narrator has gone against Maxim's wishes and visited the cottage

Analysis

- In this quote, Maxim uses strong language such as "bloody place" and "God-damned cottage" to indicate his aversion to Manderley and the cottage
- It reveals his painful memories and trauma associated with these places and underscores how he is haunted by them

"You despise me, don't you? ... You can't understand my shame, and loathing and disgust?" – Maxim, Chapter 20

Meaning and context

- In this chapter, the narrator is standing with Maxim in the library, having just learned that he killed Rebecca
- Maxim reveals the full truth about his marriage to Rebecca

Analysis

- While Maxim is generally portrayed as **stoic** and reserved, this quote reveals a more vulnerable side to his character
- The phrase "you can't understand my shame" indicates the disconnect between Maxim and the narrator
- As a character, Maxim is haunted by his past and his tumultuous marriage to Rebecca

Class Divisions

Rebecca explores the power imbalances associated with class distinctions. The narrator's lower class and interactions between the aristocratic de Winter family and the estate's staff convey the control mechanisms present in hierarchical social structures.

"I could see she despised me, marking with all the snobbery of her class that I was no great lady, that I was humble, shy, and diffident" – Narrator, Chapter 7

Meaning and context

- In this chapter, the narrator has just arrived at Manderley and has been shown to her new bedroom by Mrs Danvers
- Mrs Danvers explains that she has been at Manderley since the first Mrs de Winter married

Analysis

- This quote highlights the theme of class distinctions:
  - Here, the narrator is acutely aware of the snobbery and disdain directed towards her by Mrs Danvers
- The word "despise" conveys the strong sense of contempt that Mrs Danvers holds towards the narrator
- Mrs Danvers looks down upon the narrator for her perceived lack of social standing
- The words "no great lady", "humble", "shy" and "diffident" reveal the narrator's own self-perception:
  - It also highlights the criteria by which individuals are judged within the social hierarchy of the novel

Teacher only

Test your students on this in just a few clicks

Create exam-aligned tests

Try Test Builder

Was this revision note helpful? Yes No

Previous Next

Course Study tools All topics

Resources

Learning Hub
Scholarship
Join
Past Papers
Solution Banks
Sitemap

Dashboard

Overview
Brand ambassador
Profile
Subscription
Settings
Log out

Company

About us
Exam Specificity
Content Quality
Promotions
Jobs
Terms
Privacy
Cookie Policy
Help and Support

Subjects

Biology
Chemistry
Physics
Maths
Geography
English Literature
Psychology
All Subjects

© Copyright 2015–2026 Save My Exams Ltd. All Rights Reserved.